

are brilliant. We've never thought to apply that level of rigor to our thinking about new products before.' ”

As a result of these interactions, he has developed a reputation within his large company as a brilliant employee. This has been good for his career but very frustrating for him personally. Why? Because although he is quite brilliant, his insights into flawed product plans are due not to his special intelligence but to having a theory that allows him to predict what will happen and propose alternatives. He is frustrated because the managers he is pitching his ideas to do not see the system. They wrongly conclude that the key to success is finding brilliant people like him to put on their teams. They are failing to see the opportunity he is really presenting them: to achieve better results systematically by changing their beliefs about how innovation happens.

Putting the System First: Some Dangers

Like Taylor before us, our challenge is to persuade the managers of modern corporations to put the system first. However, Taylorism should act as a cautionary tale, and it is important to learn the lessons of history as we bring these new ideas to a more mainstream audience.

Taylor is remembered for his focus on systematic practice rather than individual brilliance. Here is the full quote from *The Principles of Scientific Management* that includes the famous line about putting the system first:

In the future it will be appreciated that our leaders must be trained right as well as born right, and that no great man can (with the old system of personal management) hope to compete with a number of ordinary men who have been properly organized so as efficiently to cooperate.

In the past the man has been first; in the future the system must be first. This in no sense, however, implies that great men are not needed. On the contrary, the first object of any